

Q When should I try to get my baby into a routine?

In the early weeks it is a good idea to begin to teach your baby the difference between day and night, but don't worry about a routine yet.

This can be hard and you may also need to surrender yourself to your baby's world by sleeping when he sleeps, if possible. He has arrived in your world with his own around-the-clock schedule.

Newborn babies sleep for much of the time, around 14 to 18 hours in every 24, but this sleep is broken up into segments. Your baby's tiny tummy can hold only a little food, so he needs to wake every two to three hours to be fed. As your baby and his tummy grow, he will be able to go longer between being fed and a routine will emerge. A degree of flexibility is key, though—accept that sometimes your baby's needs may vary from the routine.

During these first few weeks you can subtly introduce the idea of night and day: dimming lights, reducing activity in the evening, and gradually introducing an end-of-day wind down that will evolve into a bedtime routine. Your baby will need to be fed at night for a while and it is a good idea to give these in a calm, quiet environment. If you can see past the fatigue, try to cherish these first special weeks with your new baby. This time spent cocooned with her is fleeting, and you are likely to look back on it with a sense of awe.



Night shift Try to help your baby understand the difference between day and night by dimming lights.

After **six weeks** your baby may begin to sleep for longer periods during the night and slightly less during the day.

Q Why is my baby often fussy when I put him down for a nap?

This happens if you miss the nap-time window, since overstimulation and overtiredness make it harder for your baby to settle down. In the first three months, your baby will start to have longer periods of alertness between naps, but he will still be doing a lot of sleeping around the clock, so it's important that he gets his daytime

naps. It can be tricky to time naps since babies can move quickly from being awake and alert to being a little tired, then extremely tired. The moment to put your baby down is that period when tiredness is just starting to kick in, since this is the moment he will be best able to settle down to sleep. Tiredness cues can be as subtle as glancing away or looking a bit glazed. He may become fidgety and make jerky movements, and may clench his fists, tug his ears, or flutter his eyelids. Look for all these cues.

Q My baby often cries when he's at home with me. Is he bored?

At home, it may often be just the two of you, and the onus to keep your baby entertained and happy falls on your shoulders, which can feel like a burden. Don't try to entertain him every waking minute. He will thrive on the one-on-one attention he gets during 10 minutes of uninterrupted time with you, and he is then likely to coo happily on his play mat for 20 minutes, or be content watching you as you get on with chores.

Moving your baby around the house with you will help him feel secure and confident that you are close by, and this can make him less fretful. Newborns enjoy looking at the world around them so place him by an interesting house plant, a window, or patterned wallpaper to keep him fascinated, and keep changing the view. Remember that your baby knows that you are the one who meets his needs, and his cries are his way of communicating with you—when it's just the two of you, he may be more focused on his needs.

Q My friends and family want to visit the baby. How can I manage the visits so I am not overwhelmed?

When you return home from the hospital, you and your baby need plenty of time to adjust.

Eager visitors need to understand this and their expectations should be managed. It is a good idea to invite them for a short visit and limit visits to one or two per day with space between them. Let them know when you are tired and need to rest. Close friends and family may want to help so try to think of a task to give them such as shopping or small household chores.



Did you know...

As little as 5–10 minutes of deep relaxation can refresh you. Instead of doing housework, try taking a short nap while your baby sleeps. It is a good idea to learn about different relaxation techniques either online or from your local library.